Speaking at a 2016 technology summit in Bangalore, India's then–Foreign Secretary S. Jaishankar further emphasised his country's innovative distinctiveness as a comparative advantage. Recognising that "India is alone in attempting such sweeping [socioeconomic and technological] transformations in a democratic framework," he emphasised that the country's "more pluralistic social environment" and "socio-political realities ... leave little doubt that this heterogeneity not only promotes creativity in India, but could condition us to be more effective in our interactions with the world."[64]

The underlying assumption of such messages posits that India's social diversity and democratic framework offer an extraordinarily fertile experience of economic development through non-governmental innovation. Rather than being driven by the state, this line of thinking suggests that India's developmental model is more sustainable because it is anchored in the country's inherent culture of social entrepreneurship. This focus on society-driven innovation as an Indian advantage seeks to emphasise a distinction from China's focus on the hard economics of trade and investment in Beijing's economic diplomacy. To India's neighbours, and the wider developing world, this seeks to signal New Delhi's commitment to share "frugal" developmental solutions that are more sustainable, affordable, and inclusive.[65] Together, they are also used to soft balance China at the global level and to promote the cultural and innovative dimensions of India's rising economic power.

It is not easy to quantify this policy pitch. The government will naturally highlight that India has the world's third-largest number of technology driven start-ups, after the United States and the United Kingdom.[66] On the other hand, however, while ranked third globally, India only hosts 140 start-up incubators and accelerators, a far cry from China